

On-Call Rotation and Severity Definitions

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The on-call rotation runs in seven day shifts with handover every Wednesday at 10:00 EET. Wednesday was chosen over Monday deliberately: a handover on Monday means the outgoing engineer spends their weekend knowing they must be coherent on Monday morning, and a midweek handover has consistently produced better written handover notes. Each shift has a primary and a secondary. The primary takes all pages. The secondary is paged only when the primary has not acknowledged within ten minutes, and is otherwise expected to be available for a second opinion rather than to be actively watching anything.

Only engineers who have completed a shadow shift are added to the rotation. A shadow shift is a full seven days in which the engineer receives every page that the primary receives but is not responsible for responding to any of them. New engineers typically shadow in their second or third month. There is no seniority requirement beyond the shadow shift, and the rotation deliberately includes engineers at every level, because a rotation composed only of senior people produces a system that only senior people can operate.

Severity definitions

Severity	Definition	Pages?	Incident channel	Postmortem
S1	Event delivery is failing or materially delayed for multiple tenants in at least one region, or customer data is at risk of loss or exposure.	Yes, immediately, any hour	Yes	Required within 5 working days
S2	A single tenant is materially affected, or a region is degraded but still delivering within acceptable latency.	Yes, immediately, any hour	Yes	At the discretion of the responder
S3	A bug with a documented workaround and no delivery impact.	No	No	No
S4	Cosmetic, internal-only, or affecting a non-production environment.	No	No	No

Table 1. Severity levels. These definitions are shared with Support, who may declare a severity directly.

The person who declares the severity is whoever notices first, not whoever is most senior and not whoever owns the affected service. Severity is revised upward or downward freely during an incident, and the value recorded in the postmortem is the final one rather than the initial one. A responder who declares S1 and downgrades to S3 twenty minutes later has done the process correctly; a responder who hesitates over the declaration in order to avoid being wrong has not. Support engineers hold the same authority to declare, and this is stated in their own escalation policy as well as here.

Compensation

Role	Rate	Paid when	Notes
Primary	400 EUR per week	With the following month's payroll	Paid whether or not any pages occurred
Secondary	150 EUR per week	With the following month's payroll	Paid whether or not any pages occurred
Public holiday shift	Additional 200 EUR	With the following month's payroll	Per public holiday in the engineer's country

Table 2. On-call compensation.

Swaps are arranged directly between engineers without manager involvement and are recorded in the rotation tool. Compensation follows the shift rather than the original assignee, so an engineer who takes over three days of someone else's week is paid for three days. The rotation tool is the source of truth for who is on call, and an unrecorded swap means the paging system will contact the wrong person, which has happened twice and on both occasions during an S1.

After an incident

Any S1 requires a written postmortem within five working days, published to the whole company rather than to engineering alone. Postmortems are blameless in a specific and limited sense: they name systems, decisions, and gaps in tooling, but they do not name the individuals who made those decisions. The reason is practical rather than sentimental. A postmortem that names people produces postmortems that omit facts. The Atlas incident postmortem from November 2025 is the reference example for the expected format and depth, and new engineers are pointed at it during onboarding.

An engineer who is paged more than three times outside working hours during a single shift may hand the remainder of that shift to the secondary without asking anyone and without providing a justification. This is a rule rather than a courtesy, and a manager who questions its use is in the wrong. Where the secondary is also exhausted, the engineering manager takes the shift; this has occurred once, during the February 2026 backlog incident.